

Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 2026/07/05	**Entry: 1**
Description	A small U.S. health care clinic experienced a security incident on Tuesday at 9:00 a.m. Ransomware was deployed encrypting the organization's computer files due to a phishing email that contained a malicious attachment. The organized group of unethical hackers demanded money in exchange for the decryption key.
Tool(s) used	None
The 5 W's	**Who**: An organization of unethical hackers sent a phishing email, and an employee unknowingly opened the email. **What**: A malicious attachment in the phishing email installed malware on an employee's computer which encrypted important files of the organization. Consequently, employees are unable to use their computers to access important files that keep the business running. **When**: The incident occurred on Tuesday at 9:00 a.m. **Where**: The incident happened in a small U.S. health care clinic specializing in delivering primary-care services.

	Why: The incident happened due to the malicious intent of the unethical hacker organization to deploy ransomware for financial gain. It also happened due to the lack of education of employees regarding phishing emails.
Additional notes	How and when did the employee discover and download the attachment on the malicious email? How was the situation handled or contained? The company must consider how to prevent future security incidents from happening.

Date: 2026/07/27	**Entry:** 2
Description	Investigated a malicious spreadsheet attachment that executed a payload when opened. Used its SHA-256 hash in VirusTotal to identify additional IoCs.
Tool(s) used	- VirusTotal - SHA-256 hashing tool - Intrusion Detection System (IDS)
The 5 W's	**Who:** An employee at the financial services company. **What:** A malicious spreadsheet attachment created multiple unauthorized executable files. **When:** The employee opened the file at 1:13 p.m.; executables were created at 1:15 p.m.; the alert was generated at 1:20 p.m. **Where:** The employee's computer. **Why:** The attachment was designed to execute a malicious payload and compromise the employee's system.

Additional notes	The SHA-256 hash is 54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b. VirusTotal can be used to identify additional IoCs associated with the malicious file.

Date: 2026/09/07	**Entry: 3**
Description	Responding to the phishing incident using playbook of the company
Tool(s) used	- VirusTotal - SHA-256 hashing tool - Intrusion Detection System (IDS)
The 5 W's	**Who:** An employee opened the malicious attachment from a sender named “Def Communications” with a mismatched email name and person named Clyde West. **What:** The sender claiming to be interested in an engineering role in the company sent an email with a malicious executable attachment, which the employee opened. **When:** The email was sent at 09:30, the employee opened the file at 1:13 p.m.; executables were created at 1:15 p.m.; the alert was generated at 1:20 p.m. **Where:** The incident happened in the employee’s computer **Why:** The attachment was designed to execute a malicious payload and compromise the employee's system, which the employee unknowingly downloaded.
Additional notes	The email has suspicious inconsistencies with the sender names, as well as

	grammatical errors in the message.

Date: 2026/09/09	**Entry: 4**
Description	The organization experienced a security incident during which an individual was able to gain unauthorized access to customer PII and financial information. The incident caused a great negative impact financially and about 50,000 customer records were affected.
Tool(s) used	- Incident Final Report - Intrusion Detection System (IDS)
The 5 W's	**Who**: An attacker was able to gain unauthorized access to customer PII and financial data. **What**: Approximately 50,000 customer records, including PII and financial information, were accessed and exfiltrated. **When**: December 28, 2022, at approximately 7:20 p.m. PT, with the initial extortion email being received on December 22. **Where**: The organization's e-commerce web application at the customer purchase confirmation pages. **Why**: The threat actor was able to exploit a forced browsing vulnerability by modifying order numbers in URLs to access other customers' data.
Additional notes	• Poor access control configuration allowed unauthorized access to customer data. • Stronger authorization rules and performing routine vulnerability scans can strengthen the system to prevent similar events in the future.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	**Entry:** Record the journal entry number.
Description	Provide a brief description about the journal entry.
Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? • **What** happened? • **When** did the incident occur? • **Where** did the incident happen? • **Why** did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

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Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? • **What** happened? • **When** did the incident occur? • **Where** did the incident happen? • **Why** did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes:

1. Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?

I think one activity that I considered slightly challenging was the activity of responding to a phishing incident according to a playbook. Being unfamiliar with a set routine of how to respond to an incident contributed to the slow analysis of the incident as well as making the proper judgement calls required time and proper analysis.

2. Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?

My understanding of incident detection and response has changed in the sense that I have gained further understanding and practical knowledge of how each incident is handled and the process that is involved in responding and resolving an incident.

3. Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?

I particularly enjoyed the concept of crowd sourcing in the utilization of VirusTotal. I liked the acknowledgement of the contributions of the entire security community and the advantages of

the entire community sharing knowledge and data in order to keep organizations and users secure.